

Theological Research Dossiers - Volume II

Evil, salvation, afterlife, family, violence, rites, ministry, sacred time, and
interreligious identity

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Working research for UNDECIDED

Research rule: distinguish primary witness, historical reconstruction, philosophical argument, theological interpretation, ethical safeguard, and institutional decision. Confidence may never outrun evidence.

1. Scope and method

Volume II extends the v0.8 Library of Witnesses method into questions that immediately affect pastoral practice, ethical boundaries, rites, family life, ministry, mortality, and interreligious relationships. The purpose is not to force a system to closure. It is to identify what can already be taught responsibly, what remains genuinely open, and what must never be used as a pretext for coercion.

- Historical evidence can establish that a teaching or practice existed without establishing its divine truth.
- Philosophical coherence does not by itself establish revelation, and scriptural authority cannot be assumed before the authority question is itself argued.
- An ethical safeguard may be adopted before a final metaphysical theory exists when the safeguard protects consent, dignity, safety, truthfulness, and accountability.
- No finding in this volume authorizes a minister or board to override the constitutional participant rights established in earlier governance volumes.

2. Current research posture

The Way now has enough evidence to establish several negative boundaries - things it should not claim or permit - while remaining intentionally nonfinal about disputed metaphysics. This asymmetry is healthy: restraint can be justified before certainty.

3. D8 - Evil, Suffering, and Theodicy

Research question

How should the Way understand suffering, moral evil, natural evil, and the apparent tension between suffering and claims about divine goodness or power?

Witness families to examine

- Hebrew Bible laments, Job, prophetic protest, and wisdom traditions
- Jesus traditions concerning suffering, compassion, healing, and unjust death
- Qur'anic traditions of trial, patience, justice, mercy, and accountability
- Buddhist analysis of dukkha and its conditions
- Philosophical arguments from evil and major theodicy families

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Human suffering is real, morally urgent, unevenly distributed, and cannot responsibly be reduced to a single cause.
Established	The existence and intensity of suffering pose a serious evidential challenge to some forms of all-powerful, all-knowing, perfectly good theism. [S1-S2]

Confidence / type	Current finding
Well-supported	Religious traditions respond differently: protest/lament, free-will accounts, soul-making, karma/rebirth, eschatological repair, mystery, compassion, and liberation all occur, but each has significant interpretive and philosophical difficulties.
Established ethical rule	No House of Prayer may presume that illness, disability, disaster, abuse, infertility, poverty, bereavement, or other suffering is divine punishment, karmic desert, weak faith, or spiritual failure without extraordinary evidence.
Established ethical rule	A theological explanation must never be used to silence lament, block medical or legal help, pressure forgiveness, excuse an abuser, or tell a victim that suffering was necessary for another person's spiritual growth.

Questions remaining open

- Whether God is omnipotent/omniscient/perfectly good in classical terms
- Whether some suffering has divinely intended purposes
- Whether there is karmic moral causation across lives
- Whether final eschatological repair can justify or redeem horrendous suffering
- Whether some forms of evil count as positive evidence against particular God-concepts

What would change the assessment?

- A coherent model that explains severe apparently gratuitous suffering without moral distortion
- Reliable evidence of moral causation beyond ordinary natural/social mechanisms
- Stronger arguments regarding divine attributes, freedom, providence, or cosmic justice

Provisional baseline for the Way

The Way may teach compassion, lament, resistance to preventable harm, care for sufferers, and epistemic restraint. It must not teach that all suffering is deserved or divinely scripted.

4. D9 - Salvation, Liberation, Healing, and Awakening

Research question

What, if anything, is the basic human problem and what constitutes its healing, liberation, reconciliation, awakening, or completion?

Witness families to examine

- Jewish themes of covenant faithfulness, repentance, deliverance, justice, and restoration
- Christian themes of reconciliation, grace, participation in divine life, forgiveness, resurrection, and salvation
- Islamic themes of submission to God, mercy, repentance, righteous action, judgment, and felicity
- Buddhist liberation from suffering, craving, ignorance, and cyclical becoming
- Hindu, Jain, mystical, and philosophical liberation traditions

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	"Salvation" is a useful comparative category but originated in particular theological contexts and can distort other traditions if treated as a universal equivalent. [S3]
Established	Religions diagnose the human condition differently; therefore their proposed ends are not simply interchangeable.
Well-supported	Across traditions there is recurring concern with transformation from alienation, ignorance, wrongdoing, bondage, suffering, disorder, or estrangement toward wholeness, reconciliation, awakening, liberation, holiness, or right relationship.
Established ethical rule	No leader or institution may sell, guarantee, withhold, or threaten a person's ultimate spiritual destiny in exchange for money, loyalty, sexual access, silence, labor, housing, votes, or continued membership.

Questions remaining open

- Whether there is one universal human spiritual problem
- Whether reconciliation with God, awakening, liberation, or moral transformation is the deepest end
- Whether multiple religious paths are genuinely salvific/liberative
- Whether salvation is possible after death
- Whether final reconciliation is universal, conditional, or otherwise structured

What would change the assessment?

- Better comparative analysis showing equivalence or incompatibility among claimed ends
- Historical and experiential evidence concerning transformative practices
- Stronger metaphysical account of personhood, God, consciousness, and death

Provisional baseline for the Way

The Way may speak provisionally of healing, liberation, reconciliation, awakening, and wholeness, while refusing to collapse them into one metaphysical claim before evidence warrants it.

5. D10 - Death, Resurrection, Rebirth, and Afterlife

Research question

What happens at death, if anything, and what kinds of postmortem continuity are coherent or evidenced?

Witness families to examine

- Jewish developments from Sheol traditions to resurrection and later eschatologies
- Christian resurrection, judgment, heaven/hell, purgation, and universalist traditions
- Islamic resurrection, judgment, paradise, hell, mercy, and disputed duration questions
- Buddhist and Hindu rebirth traditions and liberation from cycles of becoming
- Philosophical arguments concerning dualism, materialism, personal identity, resurrection, reincarnation, and consciousness

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Human cultures and religious traditions contain multiple incompatible models of postmortem existence. [S4]
Established	Bodily resurrection, disembodied survival, reincarnation/rebirth, universal reconciliation, eternal separation, annihilation, and cessation are conceptually distinct proposals, not synonyms.
Established	The philosophical possibility of an afterlife depends heavily on theories of mind, personal identity, and continuity; no single model is established merely by widespread belief. [S4]
Established	Christian traditions themselves contain substantial diversity regarding heaven, hell, punishment, freedom, and universal reconciliation. [S5]
Established pastoral rule	Funerals and memorials must distinguish memory, hope, inherited tradition, and metaphysical certainty. No officiant may claim knowledge of a deceased person's final destiny without warrant.

Questions remaining open

- Whether consciousness survives biological death
- Whether resurrection occurs and what preserves personal identity
- Whether rebirth occurs and how identity persists without a permanent self
- Whether judgment is personal, cosmic, restorative, punitive, or metaphorical
- Whether all persons are ultimately reconciled/liberated

What would change the assessment?

- Strong reproducible evidence of postmortem consciousness or verified past-life memory
- A compelling theory of personal identity across death
- Stronger historical evidence for specific resurrection/rebirth claims

- A more coherent account of divine justice and universal destiny

Provisional baseline for the Way

The Way adopts hope without fabrication: death is certain; grief is real; ultimate destiny remains an open question. Memorial practice may express hope while naming uncertainty.

6. D11 - Sexuality, Marriage, Family, and Intimate Ethics

Research question

What ethical principles should govern sexuality, marriage, partnership, family, celibacy, parenting, and intimate power?

Witness families to examine

- Jewish, Christian, and Islamic marriage/family law and theology in diverse historical forms
- Buddhist monastic and lay sexual ethics
- Contemporary family structures and empirical research on religion and family
- Modern theological debates concerning gender, sexuality, marriage, celibacy, divorce, and same-sex relationships

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Religious teachings on sexuality and family vary substantially across traditions and within traditions over time. [S6-S7]
Established	Marriage has served multiple functions historically: kinship, property, procreation, companionship, covenant, sacrament, social order, and legal status; one function should not be projected backward as the only universal meaning.
Established ethical rule	Valid intimate relationships require capacity, meaningful consent, freedom from coercion, truthfulness about commitments, and protection from exploitation.
Established ethical rule	Sexual access can never be a privilege of spiritual office. Pastoral, ministerial, therapeutic-like, residential, employment, or dependency power requires heightened boundaries.
Established ethical rule	Children cannot consent to sexual activity with adults; safeguarding supersedes claims of custom, revelation, marriage arrangement, spiritual status, or family authority.
Well-supported	Stable care, equitable responsibility, nonviolence, honesty, fidelity to freely undertaken commitments, and protection of dependents are strong cross-context ethical goods even where family forms differ.

Questions remaining open

- Whether marriage should become a sacrament/rite of the Way
- The Way's theology of sex difference, gender, celibacy, contraception, divorce/remarriage, and same-sex unions
- Whether plural marriage can ever meet the Way's equality/noncoercion standards
- How dual-religion/interfaith marriages should be recognized ritually

- The relationship between procreation and marriage

What would change the assessment?

- Careful textual/historical research by tradition
- Evidence concerning flourishing, harm, coercion, children, dependency, and family stability
- Coherent theological account of body, personhood, covenant, and sexuality

Provisional baseline for the Way

Before settling disputed sexual theology, the Way can already require consent, non-exploitation, honesty, care, safeguarding, and equality before institutional processes. No Companion is required to marry, reproduce, remain married, or disclose intimate information to retain spiritual standing.

7. D12 - Violence, Nonviolence, Defense, and Peace

Research question

Does the Way require pacifism, permit defensive force, or recognize justifiable violence under limited conditions?

Witness families to examine

- Hebrew Bible traditions ranging from warfare to prophetic peace visions
- Jesus traditions concerning enemy-love, peacemaking, nonretaliation, and protection of the vulnerable
- Islamic texts and jurisprudential traditions on conflict, restraint, defense, peace, and no compulsion
- Buddhist and Jain non-harming traditions
- Christian pacifist and just-war traditions; modern philosophical pacifism

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Pacifism itself contains multiple positions, from absolute nonviolence to narrower opposition to war. [S8]
Established	Religious traditions contain both peace-making resources and texts/traditions used to justify force; selective quotation can conceal this internal diversity.
Established institutional rule	No founder, minister, elder, council, or House of Prayer may declare a private war, authorize vigilantism, command violence, create armed religious enforcement, or claim revelatory exemption from civil law.
Established ethical rule	Peace obtained by coercive domination is not sufficient merely because overt conflict has stopped; justice and protection of vulnerable persons matter. [S8]
Well-supported	The Way should begin with a strong presumption for nonviolent prevention, de-escalation, reconciliation where safe, restorative practices, and peacebuilding.

Questions remaining open

- Whether absolute pacifism is ultimately required
- Whether proportionate force in immediate defense of self or others is morally permissible
- Whether participation in military or police service is compatible with the Way
- How to evaluate state warfare, humanitarian intervention, and resistance to tyranny

What would change the assessment?

- A stronger theological account of enemy-love, justice, state authority, and protection obligations
- Historical evidence about outcomes of violent and nonviolent resistance
- Moral analysis of extreme rescue and defense cases

Provisional baseline for the Way

The Way adopts a presumption toward nonviolence and peacemaking but does not yet declare absolute pacifism. Religious authority never grants an independent license to harm.

8. D13 - Rites, Sacraments, Symbols, and Sacred Mediation

Research question

What can rites do, and do any rites mediate divine grace or spiritual reality beyond their communal, ethical, and psychological functions?

Witness families to examine

- Jewish ritual, covenantal, purity, festival, and lifecycle practices
- Christian sacramental, ordinance, baptismal, eucharistic, marriage, healing, and funerary traditions
- Islamic prayer, fasting, pilgrimage, almsgiving, recitation, and lifecycle practice
- Buddhist refuge, precepts, ordination, meditation, offering, funeral, and merit practices
- Anthropological and historical study of ritual and rites of passage

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Rites create and transmit meaning, memory, identity, commitment, and communal transition even before metaphysical efficacy is established.
Established	Religions differ sharply over whether rites symbolize grace, convey grace, enact covenant, transform status, purify, generate merit, or function principally as communal practice.
Established institutional rule	No rite may erase consent, create ownership of a person, bypass safeguarding, transfer property automatically, impose an irreversible child commitment, or authorize sexual/financial access.
Established	A community can responsibly practice provisional rites while clearly labeling what is symbolic, hoped, inherited, or doctrinally unresolved.

Questions remaining open

- Whether any rite objectively mediates divine grace
- Whether the Way should have baptism-like initiation, eucharistic/sacramental meal, marriage sacrament, anointing, confession, or funerary sacrament
- Whether physical substances/gestures can carry objective sacred status
- Which rites require commissioned ministers and which belong to all Companions

What would change the assessment?

- Historical-theological evidence concerning source traditions
- Longitudinal experience of the Way's provisional rites
- A developed theology of God, embodiment, community, and mediation

Provisional baseline for the Way

Rites may be used now as truthful communal practices whose claimed efficacy is no stronger than the evidence and theology supporting them.

9. D14 - Ordination, Ministry, Charisma, and Religious Office

Research question

Should the Way recognize an ordained clergy, and if so what is conferred by ordination?

Witness families to examine

- Israelite priestly, prophetic, scribal, and elder roles
- Early Christian apostles, overseers, elders, deacons, teachers, and later ordination traditions
- Islamic scholars, imams, jurists, Sufi guides, and non-sacramental leadership patterns
- Buddhist and Jain monastic ordination systems
- Sikh, Quaker, and other traditions with differing clergy/laity structures

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Ordination is not one universal religious institution; communities construct religious office differently and encode different theologies in rites. [S9-S10]
Established	Historical charisma and institutional office are distinguishable; claims of spiritual gifting do not automatically create legal, financial, disciplinary, or safeguarding authority.
Established institutional rule	The Way's current commissioning system is sufficient to authorize defined ministry functions without asserting ontological superiority.
Established institutional rule	No ordination or commissioning may grant immunity, doctrinal infallibility, founder-like succession, sexual access, control over another adult's conscience, or unilateral authority over money/property.

Questions remaining open

- Whether ordination should eventually be adopted in addition to commissioning
- Whether ordination changes status sacramentally/ontologically or only authorizes function
- Whether ministry should be time-limited, renewable, lifelong, or mixed by role
- Which ministries require formal credentialing

What would change the assessment?

- Developed theology of sacred mediation and vocation
- Practical experience across multiple Houses
- Comparative study of clericalization, abuse risks, and durable ministry formation

Provisional baseline for the Way

Commissioning remains the operative authorization. Ordination stays reserved until theology requires something commissioning cannot truthfully express.

10. D15 - Sacred Time, Weekly Rhythm, Calendar, Fasting, and Festivals

Research question

How should the Way organize recurring sacred time without fabricating ancient authority or prematurely freezing a calendar?

Witness families to examine

- Jewish Sabbath and festival cycles
- Christian weekly and annual liturgical calendars
- Islamic daily prayer, Friday gathering, lunar calendar, Ramadan, pilgrimage seasons, and feasts
- Buddhist lunar observances, Vesak and regional festival cycles
- Seasonal, agricultural, commemorative, penitential, and pilgrimage calendars across traditions

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Religious calendars do more than mark dates: recurring ritual time shapes memory, identity, practice, generosity, repentance, and community. [S11-S13,S19-S20]
Established	The seven-day sacred rhythm has enormous historical influence, but traditions locate sacred weekly gathering differently. [S12]
Established	Festivals often combine remembered events, natural cycles, communal meals, prayer, generosity, fasting, pilgrimage, and teaching rather than serving one function only.
Established ethical rule	Fasting and vigils must include health, age, pregnancy, disability, medication, eating-disorder, labor, and other exemptions; spiritual status must never depend on unsafe observance.

Questions remaining open

- Which day or days should carry primary weekly communal significance
- Whether the Way adopts a distinctive calendar or uses civil/local calendars with an observance overlay
- Which historical events deserve annual remembrance
- Whether fasting becomes normative, optional, seasonal, or remains individual
- How inherited Jewish, Christian, Islamic, Buddhist, and other holy days should be observed by Companions

What would change the assessment?

- Actual practice and needs of Houses of Prayer
- Theology of creation, revelation, historical memory, and rest
- Calendar research and global cultural/astronomical practicality

Provisional baseline for the Way

Adopt recurring sacred rhythm before adopting a total calendar: regular prayer, weekly communal gathering/rest rhythm, periodic service and self-examination, and annual remembrance may develop experimentally with transparent revision.

11. D16 - Interreligious Identity, Dialogue, Conversion, and Dual Belonging

Research question

How should the Way relate to other religions and to Companions who retain, revise, or relinquish prior religious identities?

Witness families to examine

- Abrahamic claims of continuity, fulfillment, supersession, covenant, prophecy, and finality
- Buddhist transmission and adaptation across cultures
- Sikh and Bahá'í engagements with religious plurality
- Modern interreligious dialogue principles
- Historical conversion movements and coercive/voluntary conversion patterns

Current findings

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Religions make genuinely different and sometimes contradictory truth claims; respectful dialogue does not require pretending all claims are identical. [S14,S17]
Established	Religious conversion historically ranges from highly voluntary to socially or politically coerced; volition therefore requires explicit protection. [S16]
Established ethical rule	The Way prohibits compelled conversion and institutional penalties for declining conversion. The Qur'anic no-compulsion witness is one important historical source among others for this principle. [S15]
Established	Source traditions must be represented in their own terms before the Way evaluates them. The Way should not strip-mine traditions for attractive practices while ignoring context, ownership, history, or living communities.
Established institutional rule	Companions may maintain ordinary family, friendship, study, worship-visiting, and dialogue relationships outside the Way; leaders may not require social isolation.

Questions remaining open

- Whether formal dual religious belonging is coherent for every combination of traditions
- Whether the Way eventually understands itself as a new religion, reform movement, meta-tradition, fellowship, or another category
- Whether some source traditions are uniquely revelatory or salvifically normative
- How to handle incompatible initiation vows or exclusive doctrinal commitments

What would change the assessment?

- Long-term lived experience of Companions with multiple inheritances

- Dialogue with representatives and scholars of source traditions
- Further research on truth, revelation, salvation/liberation, and religious identity

Provisional baseline for the Way

The Way practices neither "all religions are the same" nor "all others are false." It adopts disciplined hospitality: learn accurately, preserve disagreement, protect conscience, cooperate in good work, and test claims without coercion.

12. Cross-dossier synthesis

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	The institution can impose stricter safeguards on its own power than its metaphysics can presently justify about the universe.
Established	Suffering, sexuality, mortality, violence, ritual, ministry, and religious identity are all domains in which overclaiming certainty can create direct harm.
Well-supported	The Way should prefer reversible, reviewable, consent-based religious practices while its theology remains provisional.
Well-supported	The next theological maturation should come through accumulated practice, longitudinal evidence, primary-source study, and dialogue with living traditions rather than rapid doctrinal closure.

13. Teaching rule for Houses of Prayer

When teaching a disputed subject, a Teacher or Minister should state four things whenever material: (1) what the relevant witnesses actually say, (2) what historians or philosophers can reasonably infer, (3) what the Assembly currently teaches and at what confidence, and (4) what remains open. Personal conviction may be shared as personal conviction, not silently upgraded to doctrine.

Source notes

S1 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "The Problem of Evil". Problem of evil; logical/evidential distinction; defenses and theodicies.

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/evil/>

S2 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Theodicies". Contemporary account of theodicy and severe suffering.

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S4 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Afterlife". Philosophical possibilities for survival, resurrection, and rebirth.

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S7 - Oxford Handbook of Psychology and Spirituality, "Questions Left Unaddressed by Religious Familism". Plurality of contemporary family forms and religion/spirituality.

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S8 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Pacifism". Spectrum from nonviolence to anti-war pacifism and just-war contrast.
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<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/28032/chapter-abstract/211916688>

S14 - World Council of Churches, Guidelines for Dialogue and Relations with People of Other Religions. Interreligious dialogue, cooperation, and respect across conviction differences.
<https://www.oikoumene.org/resources/documents/guidelines-for-dialogue-and-relations-with-people-of-other-religions>

S15 - Qur'anic Arabic Corpus / Qur'an 2:256. Primary witness to the no-compulsion principle in Qur'anic tradition.
<https://corpus.quran.com/translation.jsp?chapter=2&verse=256>

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<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/34732/chapter-abstract/296512497>

S17 - Oxford Handbook of the Abrahamic Religions. Comparative study of Jewish, Christian, and Islamic beliefs, rituals, and interaction.
<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/34340>

S18 - Oxford Academic, "Islam and the Fate of Others". Diversity of Muslim views regarding salvation of non-Muslims and hell.
<https://academic.oup.com/book/5856>

S19 - Oxford Academic, "The calendar and festivals" in Judaism: A Very Short Introduction. Calendar integrates memory, worship, generosity, fasting, and natural cycles.
<https://academic.oup.com/book/62733/chapter-abstract/562692919>

S20 - Oxford Academic, "Fasting in Islam". Ramadan fasting as recurring sacred practice linked with charity and family/community.
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